

7. DEPARTURE:

THE EMERGENCE OF A SYNDICALIST INTERNATIONAL

When the International Syndicalist Bureau informed Moscow of the decisions of the June conference, and invited RILU affiliates to participate in the forthcoming syndicalist congress, which would seek joint action "against the two scourges of the working class - Capitalism and the State," the RILU Executive replied that it could not squander its time on such a frivolous undertaking. The June conference, Lozovskii wrote, had sat in judgment upon the Russian Revolution and had mistreated the Russian trade unions. He dismissed the proposed congress as a schismatic enterprise, in contrast to the impending RILU congress to which divergent revolutionary organizations were invited, he argued, not to be judged but to lay a foundation for common action. The RILU Executive counselled the Bureau "in all comradeship" to abandon its attempt to found yet another International.¹

Rudolf Rocker responded on behalf of the Bureau. Renewing its invitation, he stressed that the essential issue was how to achieve a single revolutionary trade union International. If the RILU valued the united front as more than a handy formula, its goal was that of the Bureau. Given the contrasting communist and syndicalist principles on revolutionary unionism and the role of political parties, mutual understanding required a degree of tolerance. The RILU accused the syndicalists of sectarianism, but had the founding congress of the RILU not sought to implant an exclusive policy of state communism within the workers' movement? A united International, Rocker argued, must encompass three divergent groups: those like the Russian trade unions, who accepted the complete subordination of a labour International to the CI and of national unions to communist parties; those who accepted the "organic link" between a trade union International and the CI and mutual representation between unions and parties at the national and international level; and those, like the syndicalists, who demanded the complete independence of the unions from parties nationally and internationally. Only formal recognition of the unions' right to determine their relationship with political parties would make coexistence possible. The second RILU congress, which would precede the Berlin meeting, could pave the way towards proletarian unity by abandoning its earlier schismatic policy. To ignore this opportunity to promote

workers' unity would be to sanction a split in the international movement. On behalf of the Bureau, Rocker concluded by advising the RILU Executive, "in all comradeship," to embrace the cause of revolutionary unity in the hope "that the revolutionary spirit will finally attain its rights over party spirit."² No reply appeared, for at this point the RILU Executive broke off the correspondence. When the congress convened on 25 December 1922, no RILU affiliates were present.

The Troubled Odyssey of Alexander Schapiro

The differences between the Syndicalist Bureau in Berlin and the communists in Moscow soon extended to wider issues, tactical and personal, which further called into question the possibility of cooperation between syndicalists and communists. One concerned the Bureau's proposal that RILU affiliates and syndicalist organizations jointly boycott Italian goods, and impede traffic into Italian harbours, in the wake of the fascist victory and the continuing attack upon the workers' movement in Italy, a proposal that Lozovskii rejected.³ Another involved the fate of Alexander Schapiro, a member of the Syndicalist Bureau, who had been imprisoned in Moscow.

Schapiro's life paralleled the main developments in the history of the libertarian left in the early decades of the twentieth century, and he therefore seemed almost fated to be carried into a confrontation, both highly personal and symbolic, with the Bolsheviks. A Russian taken into exile in his childhood, Schapiro from his adolescence onward had been involved in the international libertarian movement, to which he had made many administrative contributions. He had stood with the libertarian internationalists in opposing the First World War, and his antiwar activities had earned him imprisonment in Britain. Following the events of February 1917 in Russia, Schapiro had immediately returned to offer his services to his revolutionary homeland. For Schapiro, one duty – that of defending the interests of the only socialist nation within a world of imperialist states – led him to work for the government's Commissariat of Foreign Affairs, while another duty – that of defending the early libertarian impulses of the Revolution, which soon meant primarily resisting the encroachments of Bolshevik centralization and political dictatorship – led him to devote his free time to the syndicalist movement, primarily to the work of the 'Golos Truda' publishing house. But there was never any question about Schapiro's ultimate commitment. Schapiro had never hesitated to speak out against the Bolsheviks,

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although he originally did so temperately. As their dictatorship rigidified, as the persecution of the libertarians mounted, his once moderate criticisms of the regime intensified.

Whatever reservations the Russian libertarians and their foreign sympathizers had about protesting abroad about the persecution of native libertarians, while Russia suffered civil war and foreign intervention, receded late in 1920, as these dangers declined. But Bolshevik repression of the revolutionary left in Russia continued unabated into 1921, and indeed intensified, particularly with the wave of arrests that accompanied the suppression of the Kronstadt rising in March. To many libertarians, both inside and outside Russia, the need was no longer for silence, but for public protest against Bolshevik repression.

Given Schapiro's long internationalist commitment and devotion, it was natural that he would now seek to alert the international labour movement to the situation in Russia. Schapiro, moreover, was now nearly the only spokesman of the native syndicalist movement at liberty in Russia, and he regarded it as incumbent upon him to speak out on behalf of his imprisoned comrades. He therefore continued his audacious criticism of the government. Ultimately his audacity proved intolerable to the Bolsheviks, who acted to silence him. After he had given over four years' of effort to the Russian Revolution, a Bolshevik dictatorship made of the adult Schapiro what a Tsarist dictatorship had made of him as a child: an exile. And what prompted the Bolsheviks to act against him were Schapiro's international efforts.

Schapiro's efforts were shared by two anarchist who had also spent many years outside Russia, Alexander Berkman and Emma Goldman, deported to Russia from the USA in 1919. The trio believed it increasingly urgent to inform the revolutionaries of the West of the situation in Russia as 1921 progressed. They would use every means at their limited disposal. They utilized the personal network of libertarians in the West. Berkman and Schapiro, for example, had helped to organize an anarchist demonstration in Moscow on the occasion of Kropotkin's funeral in February, and they used their report of these events to western libertarians to call attention to the fate of those in Russia, some of whom had to be released from prison to attend. Schapiro, Goldman, Berkman and others also utilized the radical press in the West, as they did to protest the Kronstadt events in March.⁴ They also prepared more detailed indictments of the Bolshevik regime for western consumption. Joined by the anarchist Aleksei Borovoi, who had been dismissed from Moscow University, the three in June wrote a brochure on *The Russian Revolution and the Communist Party*, which was smuggled to the West

and published anonymously under Rudolf Rocker's supervision in Germany. The libertarians of Russia, the authors asserted, had initially been reluctant to protest abroad about their fate, while the civil war in Russia continued, for fear that protesting might prejudice "the interests of the Russian Revolution and . . . aid the common enemy, world imperialism." But while foreign intervention had not succeeded against the revolutionary will of the Russian people, the civil war had permitted a communist dictatorship to become entrenched in Russia. Only with the conclusion of civil war had it become "evident that the most formidable danger to the Revolution was not outside, but *within* the country: a danger resulting from the very nature of the social and economic arrangements which characterize the present 'transitory stage'."⁵ Schapiro, Berkman and Goldman also seized the opportunity of the founding congress of the RILU, in July, to apprise foreign delegates of circumstances in Russia, and also to mobilize them to win the release of a number of imprisoned Russian syndicalist leaders, who were later deported.

But for the few Russian libertarians still at liberty, almost no possibility of constructive work existed in Russia after March 1921. The efforts of the Russian syndicalists, in fact, had long been almost entirely defensive. Alexander Berkman's diary entry for 30 September not only expressed his own intentions, but captured the despair of the libertarians, who believed the Russian Revolution had long been subverted:

Grey are the passing days. One by one the embers of hope have died out. Terror and despotism have crushed the life born in October. The slogans of the Revolution are foresworn, its ideals stifled in the blood of the people. . . . Dictatorship is trampling the masses under foot. The Revolution is dead; its spirit cries in the wilderness.

High time the truth about the Bolsheviki were told. . . . the clay feet of the fetish beguiling the international proletariat to fatal will o' the wisps exposed. The Bolshevik myth must be destroyed.

I have decided to leave Russia.⁶

Berkman, Goldman and Schapiro left Russia late in 1921, hoping to attend an international anarchist congress to be held in Berlin in December.⁷ But Schapiro and his comrades, delayed *en route*, were unable to attend. They arrived in Stockholm in January 1922, and Goldman soon began a series of articles on the Russian situation, republished later in the year as *The Crushing of the Russian Revolution*. Berkman also contributed to the effort to publicize Bolshevik subversion of the Revolution by writing *The Russian Tragedy* and *The Kronstadt Rebellion*, and preparing an English edition of *The Russian Revolution*

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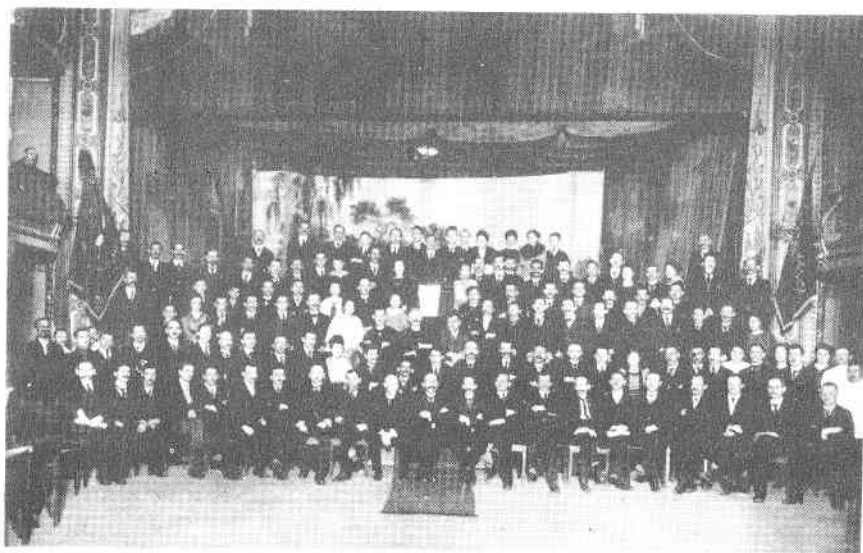
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and the Communist Party, all published in Berlin in 1922.⁸ Schapiro later joined the deported Russian syndicalist leaders in Berlin. They now lent their support to efforts to establish an independent syndicalist International, and Schapiro participated in the preparations for the June conference, in which he and Mratchnyi – speaking for the Russian syndicalist minority – came into sharp conflict with the delegate of the All-Russian Trade Unions over the issue of repression within the Russian labour movement. The conference named Schapiro to represent the Russian syndicalists in the Syndicalist Bureau it established.

Unlike Goldman and Berkman, whose immediate objective was to publicize abroad the fate of the Russian Revolution, and who had no intention of returning to Russia, Schapiro believed that however bleak the prospects he should continue his work there. In Berlin Schapiro had the opportunity to consult Chicherin, the head of the Bolshevik Commissariat of Foreign Affairs, whom Schapiro had known for years. Despite Schapiro's activities in the international syndicalist movement, and the fact that he had joined anarchists in the West in protesting the persecution of those in Russia, Chicherin assured him that the Russian government would create no difficulties about his return. Chicherin instructed the Russian consul to expedite Schapiro's journey, and the books and papers Schapiro had collected abroad were even returned to Russia by diplomatic courier. Schapiro left Berlin in August. On the night of 2-3 September, two weeks after his return, he was arrested in Moscow by the secret police and imprisoned.

Schapiro dismissed the charge against him of having entered into relations with underground anarchists upon his return to Russia. He pointed out that the secret police were above all interested in his foreign contacts, and that the order later expelling him from Russia mentioned only his anti-Soviet activities abroad. A letter from the incarcerated Schapiro to Chicherin went unanswered, and the RILU declined to act on Schapiro's request that the Syndicalist Bureau in Berlin be notified of the imprisonment of its Russian representative. The news nevertheless soon reached the West, and the Bureau immediately called upon international labour to act to win Schapiro's release.⁹ The RILU Executive soon began to receive protests and queries concerning Schapiro's case from various sources in the West, including the French CDS. The Executive found Schapiro's case to be embarrassing, in general because for all who knew Schapiro it demonstrated the baselessness of Bolshevik claims that the Russian government never imprisoned libertarians who had done nothing illegal, more specifically because the



The German FAUD emerged as one of the earliest revolutionary organizations to criticize communist internationalism. Above: the November 1922 congress of the FAUD. The FAUD would host the founding meeting of a syndicalist International a month later.



Some participants in the founding congress of the IWMA, Berlin, December 1922. From left, standing: Ritter and Schuster (Germany), Borghi (Italy), Lindstam (Sweden), van Zelm and Dissel (The Netherlands). Seated: Orlando (Argentina), Souchy (Germany), Schapiro (Russia), Rocker (Germany), Giovanetti (Italy), Lansink Jr. (The Netherlands). Seated in front: Severin (Sweden), D'Andrea (Italy), Abad de Santillan (Argentina).

Executive did not want to jeopardize the prospective affiliation of the French CGTU with the RILU. At any rate the RILU Executive and the All-Russian Trade Unions suggested that Schapiro be released, but also expelled from Russia.¹⁰ The irony of the date of his expulsion did not escape Schapiro. He had "the exceptional honour," as he sardonically put it, of being evicted from Russian soil on the fifth anniversary of the second Russian Revolution. Five years earlier he had been in Petrograd when the Revolution began, "when all our hearts beat in unison and acclaimed the advent of the emancipation of labour."¹¹

Back in the West, Schapiro became the most active of the Russian syndicalists in exile. The deported Russians now could act on behalf of syndicalism in Russia only from outside, and Schapiro became a prime mover in the committee of exiles who published *Rabochii Put'* (*The Workers' Way*), a syndicalist journal produced in Berlin for clandestine dissemination in Russia. *Rabochii Put'* began publication in March 1923 with financial support from the newly-founded syndicalist International. Schapiro had returned to Berlin in time to act as a strong advocate of the formation of such an International in the syndicalist congress of December 1922.

The Founding of the International Working Men's Association

Over thirty delegates assembled at Berlin for the congress, which claimed to represent over two million workers.¹² Fifteen countries were represented either directly or indirectly. Deliberative votes were allotted to the FAUD (represented by Kater, Souchy, Ritter, Schuster, Kettenback, Bittner, Hundt and Schlisch), the USI (Giovanetti, Gradi), the SAC (Severin, Lindstam), and NAS (Dissel, van Zelm, Schenk), the NSF (Smith), the Danish *Syndikalistik Propagandaforbund* (Manus), the FORA (Abad de Santillan, Orlando), and the CGT-M (Rocker). The CGT-P had sent its consent and was also recognized as a full member of the congress, as were the IWW-C, whose delegate (Montaca) arrived only after the congress was over, and the CNT, whose delegates were arrested before they reached Berlin. A representative of the FORU also arrived too late to participate. Consultative votes were allotted to a number of organizations, including the CDS (Besnard, Lemoine), the *Allgemeine Arbeiter-Union Einheitsorganisation* (AAUE) (Pfempfer, Allmer), the Russian Syndicalist Minority (Schapiro, Iarchuk), and the Czechoslovakian *Freie Arbeiter-Union* (Novak). Lansink Jr. of Holland

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and Rocker of Germany were granted consultative votes as representatives of the International Syndicalist Information Bureaus, founded in December 1920 and June 1922, respectively.¹³

The assembly had been postponed to December to permit assessment of the actions of the second RILU congress, but the decisions taken in Moscow had not yet officially appeared. The delegates knew only that the original article eleven of the RILU statutes, governing RILU-CI relations, had been altered, but remained unaware of the precise changes made. In most countries represented, however, the break with Moscow had already occurred; most delegates had been expressly instructed to support a new and autonomous revolutionary International. They could point to articles beginning to appear in the communist press, moreover, in which Lozovskii and other communist chieftains suggested that only insignificant changes had been made to appease the syndicalists, changes that did not modify the working relationship between the RILU and the CI. In one of the most damning of these articles, intended for a Soviet audience, Lozovskii wrote that the elimination of article eleven did "not exclude a permanent collaboration" between the CI and the RILU, "but on the contrary formally prescribes it." He continued: "Only the forms of this permanent collaboration have been modified. Instead of establishing an organic link between the two organizations by statute, action committees will be established for the application of decisions taken in common." Lozovskii explained that "this concession to prejudices will without doubt bring the syndicalist workers more intimately into harmony" not simply with the RILU, but also with the CI. "It is in this sense and in this sense alone that the concessions we have made must be understood."¹⁴ Few delegates believed that the cosmetic alterations made in Moscow had ensured the independence of the RILU; nearly all were prepared to proceed to the formation of a syndicalist international. The delegations of the CDS and of the NAS were the exceptions.

Besnard and Lemoine were in a delicate position, for while the other major delegations represented autonomous labour organizations, the French CDS was but an organized minority within the association at whose request alterations in the RILU statutes had been made, the CGTU. Those organized in the CDS, hoping to prevail within the CGTU, repudiated a split with the parent body - which had itself broken from the CGT only a year earlier - and endorsed revolutionary labour unity nationally and internationally. But the CDS also advocated the establishment of a fully autonomous revolutionary International, dedicated to the overthrow of capitalism and to the destruction of the

state. Besnard and Lemoine proved reluctant in Berlin to endorse the establishment of a new International. They denied that the suppression of article eleven had significantly altered the relationship of the RILU and the CI, but argued that this could best be demonstrated to the workers by the decisions of the RILU congress itself, about which more needed to be known. The second RILU congress had also endorsed the policy of the united front initiated by the CI, and Besnard and Lemoine recognized the propaganda value this gave the communists. They insisted that if the Berlin congress founded an International, a new Secretariat must work for a united front among all revolutionary unions, including RILU affiliates, and eventually prevailed upon the assembly to consider further negotiations with the Moscow trade union International.

Far less ambivalent, the NAS delegates alone adopted a role of unequivocal opposition in Berlin. For them the elimination of article eleven had been crucial; their mandate rested upon it. They firmly rejected the formation of a new International, calling instead upon the Syndicalist Information Bureau immediately to negotiate with the RILU concerning the affiliation of the syndicalist organizations with Moscow. Dissel argued that an internal opposition could conquer the RILU, thus ensuring the emergence of a revolutionary International free of all party influence. No other delegation considered this view realistic. The presence of Lansink, a dissenting member of the NAS Executive who represented the International Syndicalist Bureau founded in 1920, complicated the Dutch position. Lansink claimed to reflect the views of a majority of NAS members, whose referendum had rejected affiliation with the RILU in favour of founding an independent revolutionary labour International. He dismissed the hope of converting the RILU from within as illusory.

For most delegates the RILU had already sufficiently demonstrated its irredeemable character. Rocker noted that every national syndicalist organization contacted by the International Bureau in Europe and America, except that of France, had favoured an autonomous syndicalist International.¹⁵ He noted the RILU Executive's rejection of participation by its affiliates in the Berlin congress, the RILU's refusal to join syndicalist organizations in a boycott directed against Italian fascism, and the Schapiro case. Rocker and others, particularly the Italian delegates, argued that Moscow's attitude in these instances further demonstrated the need for an independent revolutionary labour International.

The delegates therefore proved unreceptive to the RILU's appeal that they renounce the formation of another International and join the RILU.

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They formally noted the RILU's appeal, but greeted it, as the NAS much later complained, with "derisive laughter."¹⁶ And when Dissel endorsed this appeal on behalf of the NAS, and Lemoine of the CDS proposed further negotiations with the RILU, numerous voices were raised in opposition. A series of delegates argued that the suppression of article eleven had not altered the character of the RILU; that its statutes provided throughout for close ties with the communist party; that the formation of an independent International could no longer be delayed. They pointed to conflicts with the communists in their own countries as demonstrating the impossibility of working with the communist-dominated RILU.

The variety of concerns and views underlying this litany of objections can be briefly sampled. The FAUD, Ritter declared, repudiated any further unity negotiations with the RILU, which served only to provide an economic basis for the communist party. "We have a socialist goal, not a radical bourgeois one like the RILU. Whether capitalism is private or state-based, in both cases it leads to economic monopoly and wage slavery." Syndicalists rejected dictatorship as incompatible with social revolution. "The RILU wants the dictatorship of the proletariat," Ritter continued, "but every dictatorship - including this one - depends inevitably upon wage slavery and the exploitation of the workers. Only when the workers are not in possession of the means of production can they be subjected to a dictatorship." The Czechoslovakians, Novak asserted, expected the congress to found an autonomous International. They regarded the RILU as "an instrument of political power for the suppression of libertarian socialism." The Swedes, Severin insisted, would neither join Moscow nor brook further delays in establishing a syndicalist International. The Argentinians' mandate bound them to support a new International, and forbade further fruitless discussions with the RILU. Santillan declared this to be the position of the Mexican and Portuguese organizations as well. Schapiro avowed that union with the RILU would contradict the syndicalist principles established by the June conference. To permit the RILU to continue as the sole International of revolutionary workers, moreover, would deal the death-blow to syndicalism in Russia. Smith reported that in Norway the communists had not only rejected undertakings in common, the last being an offer of joint action against the Italian reaction, but sought to secure the dismissal of syndicalist workers from their jobs. He declared it impossible to work together in an International with those who in Russia expelled syndicalists from the country. For the Italians the question of union with Moscow could no longer arise. As organs of the power apparatus

of the state, the Russian unions could not provide the basis for a revolutionary labour International. Giovanetti and Gradi assailed communist tactics in Italy, where Mussolini had come to power two months earlier. Communist efforts to divide the factory occupation movement of 1920, Giovanetti charged, had contributed to its failure. Assailed on the one hand by Mussolini's movement, on the other by the communists, the syndicalists had been "beset by a fascism on two fronts." When the syndicalists directly beseeched communist cooperation, Gradi declared, the communists, always placing the interests of the party above those of the revolution, had declined. "The revolution knocked on the door three times in Italy and it was always turned away by the communists." Only when the divisive policy of the communists had helped the fascists to secure victory, and all but smash the trade union movement, had the communists suggested joint action, "as if one were to challenge a crippled invalid to a race with a train." Rejecting the "timorous tactics" recommended by France and Holland, the USI delegates called for the immediate formation of a syndicalist International.¹⁷

Amid the declamatory chorus rejecting further delays the most impassioned pleas came from Rocker, who firmly dismissed any proration. "How long should we wait? How long can we wait?" he exclaimed. "One allows himself to be fooled once, to be fooled twice; but he who permits himself always to be fooled, remains a fool," Rocker asserted to fervent applause. The decisions of the RILU congress had not been released prior to the Berlin assembly because they were intentionally ambiguous and designed to prevent syndicalist unity. Not article eleven alone, moreover, but the entire character of the RILU was at issue. "Does anyone believe the mentality of the men of Moscow to be altered by the deletion of article eleven?" The united front of the proletariat, he added, arose naturally from the practical necessity of struggle, not as a result of theoretical resolutions. This had been demonstrated in Germany when members of the centralist unions had stood together with the syndicalists in the general strike that had foiled the Kapp putsch. Only the communists had been prepared to work against the united front by opposing the general strike.¹⁸ Moscow had played the same game in the struggle of the Italian syndicalists for survival. "We must finally declare clearly: the Third International and the RILU are not organizations of the revolutionary proletariat, they are agencies for the foreign policy of the Russian government." Revolutionary honour and morality forbade the syndicalists to continue to associate with those who were imprisoning and exiling Russian

syndicalists. Unlike the accommodation of all socialism that imperialism and the RILU wanted, that every creative reorganization of the final aims of the highest form of economic match for us with the condemned Moscow financial means. The sympathy for the revolution it had injected "the veins of the workers."

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syndicalists. Unlike the RILU, the new International must be able to accommodate all revolutionary unions. If one sought a dictatorial socialism that imposed its ideology on the masses from above, the CI and the RILU were appropriate organizations. "But if we maintain that every creative force must evolve from the womb of the people, that the reorganization of society must proceed from below upward, that the final aims of socialism must be a cultural question of which the highest form of expression is the class struggle, then there can be no match for us with the RILU." Like Giovanetti before him, Rocker condemned Moscow for attempting to capture labour's support by financial means. The Red International no longer won influence through sympathy for the Russian Revolution, but through the lucre by which it had injected "concentrated disgrace, shame and corruption" into the veins of the workers' movement.¹⁹

Rocker cautioned the Dutch and French that compromise with Moscow would put them in opposition to the syndicalists of Germany, Italy, Spain, Scandinavia and South America. They would also be sanctioning the policies and tactics of the Russian rulers:

If you unite with Moscow you are jointly responsible for all the repression that Russia practices against our comrades; you are jointly responsible that a handful of men are today selling Russia to international capitalism; you are jointly responsible for the quivering lips, the death-cries from the hell of Bolshevism. If you make this contract, you must underwrite it with the blood of your consciences.

Rocker agreed with Dissel that circumstances dictated a decisive struggle against world reaction, but argued that struggle led not towards the Moscow that Dissel applauded, but away from it. He observed that in 1871, following the defeat of the Paris Commune, Bakunin had asserted that the centre of the international reaction was not Paris, but the Berlin of Bismarck and social democracy. To Bakunin, the newly-founded archconservative Empire created by Bismarck, and the fledgling social democratic movement, both sought the pan-Germanization of Europe. Rocker argued that the current seat of reaction was neither Rome nor Madrid but Moscow, where the Russian regime sought nothing less than the pan-Russification of the labour movement. "Therefore," Rocker concluded, "my final words are: Break, break yet again and ever again with the powers of reaction in order to elucidate the independence of revolutionary syndicalism."²⁰

Rocker and other non-Dutch delegates expressed amazement that the NAS leaders had chosen to ignore the results of the referendum of NAS

members. Lansink also attacked the position of his fellow NAS Executives. The suppression of article eleven had been no concession, but only an attempt to prevent the foundation of a syndicalist International. Further discussion with Moscow would be superfluous. The dependence of the RILU upon the CI was undeniable. Lansink recalled being present at a discussion of the united front by the Central Committee of the RILU in Moscow, which had been adjourned with the express understanding that the RILU had to await the decision taken on this question by the CI Executive. Communist domination of the RILU precluded any hope of transforming it from within. Lansink predicted that the RILU and the IFTU, both Marxist organizations, would within a decade unite into a single centralist body.

But if we want to go from Berlin to Amsterdam, we do not need to make the great detour through Moscow. . . . We want a unified International. The prerequisite for this, though, is a unified idea. We do not find this idea in the RILU, and therefore as the representatives of the syndicalist idea, we must build our own International.²¹

Doggedly the NAS delegation argued that the position of the Executive accurately reflected the will of most NAS members. If Ritter's wholesale rejection of proletarian dictatorship were a universal criterion, Dissel maintained, the Dutch of the NAS were not syndicalists, for they recognized the dictatorship of, but not over, the proletariat. They accepted the demand of the Berlin Declaration of 1920 for a trade union International free of all political influence. The crucial striking of article eleven had brought the RILU into conformity with this requirement. Dissel lamented the current attack upon the RILU, which remained quite independent of the Russian government, in the absence of a representative to defend it.²² No one in the assembly shared the view of the NAS delegation, whose resolution on the RILU failed.

The sharply contrasting document of the SAC, noting that the very resolution altering the RILU statutes openly declared that the CI must play the leading rôle in the international sphere, asserted that the RILU willingly subordinated itself to the CI. The SAC rejected as misrepresentation the appeal of the second RILU congress to the syndicalist organizations assembled in Berlin. Upon the passage of the Swedish resolution, Dissel announced that the NAS delegates would no longer participate in the discussions. During the next session they withdrew.²³

A resolution from the German, Italian, Swedish, Norwegian, Danish and Argentinian delegations, calling for the foundation of a syndicalist International, won unanimous approval. Syndicalist efforts to found

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an autonomous International of revolutionary unionists, frustrated for ten years since the first attempt at London, had at last come to fruition. The decision of the syndicalists assembled in Berlin also meant that the attempts of the communists to unite the whole of the revolutionary workers' movement under their international tutelage had failed. To polygot refrains of 'The International' the split between libertarian and political socialists that had divided the First and Second Internationals now also split the Third.²⁴

The assembly formally noted the refusal of RILU affiliates to participate in efforts to reach mutual accord in Berlin, and condemned Lozovskii's "absolutely sectarian behaviour" toward western syndicalists as the inevitable consequence of Soviet repressive measures against the indigenous syndicalist movement. The delegates asserted that the decisions of the RILU's second congress had in no way changed the character of that organization. The subordination of syndicalism to political parties found expression throughout its statutes; the alteration of a single article deceived no one. Those who sanctioned the appeal of the second RILU congress to syndicalist organizations had become Moscow's tools, "syndicalists in the tow of the Communist International," who sought to subordinate the syndicalist movement everywhere to communist parties. The assembly declared that - in accord with the mandated instructions of a number of the European and American organizations - it had therefore founded a syndicalist International independent of all political parties and governments.²⁵ The resolution passed unanimously, and Lansink, the representatives of the Russian and Czechoslovakian syndicalists, as well as the consultative delegates of the AAUE and the CDS, also expressed their approval. The new International, to whose Secretariat Souchy, Schapiro and Rocker were elected, took Berlin as its seat.

The support of the French for the new International, however, was not unqualified. Besnard now declared that the CDS "attached itself morally" to the Berlin International, provided that the latter sought to unite all revolutionary workers dedicated to overthrowing capitalist society and the state. It must seek a united front with the revolutionary organizations that remained outside it.²⁶ Nearly all delegates could accept this declaration, for in calling for the formation of a new International, most had noted that it could work with other organizations from time to time. But the French insisted not only that the congress formally note their declaration, but that it instruct the new Secretariat to approach the RILU in a final effort to achieve international harmony. The CDS proposal specified that the approach be made on the basis of the last

letter of the International Syndicalist Bureau to the RILU, and provided that if the RILU Executive rebuffed this overture, RILU affiliates be approached directly.²⁷

This proposal - called the Resolution on Revolutionary Unity - elicited very little sympathy from remaining delegates, who regarded any further dealings with the RILU as futile, at best "an empty gesture."²⁸ The Argentinians vigorously opposed it. The FORA had earlier rejected the instructions of the June conference that the Syndicalist Bureau transmit its decisions to the RILU, and invite RILU affiliates to the Berlin congress.²⁹ A FORA declaration now sharply repudiated further transactions with Moscow. No RILU affiliate had the appropriate character to participate in the new International, which should concern itself solely with those revolutionary organizations completely independent of Moscow. The new International must combat the RILU with the same vigor that it must combat the IFTU. An "irreducible enemy" of single fronts based on compromise, the FORA urged the Berlin International to forego the search for coexistence and a concern with greater numbers, to devote itself instead to ensuring the revolutionary principles of the new organization.³⁰ As Santillan later put it, the FORA believed the unity of the proletariat to be "a metaphysical illusion," that any negotiations with the dictators of Moscow "would be a comedy destined to complete failure." The Argentinian delegation therefore urged the CDS to abandon diplomatic manoeuvres that could only undermine it, and deliver the French proletariat "to the acolytes of Moscow."³¹ An appreciation of the difficult domestic situation of the CDS nevertheless convinced the reluctant delegates to endorse the Resolution on Revolutionary Unity, with the FORA abstaining.

Before this issue had finally been resolved, however, the assembly began to formulate the statutes of the new International. This work was not without incident, but a recurring difficulty lay not in the differences between the delegates but in outside interruptions by the police. The congress was a mobile affair, held clandestinely at different sites in an attempt to elude the police. These efforts failed, however, and the police, who "steadily hunted" the participants, on three occasions located and interrupted the assembly to conduct passport checks on foreign delegates and spectators.³² In the last of these interruptions the police provoked considerable turmoil by arresting 13 people, including at least three delegates (Giovanetti, Gradi, Orlando).³³ But before the final appearance of the police the delegates had largely completed their discussion on the statutes.

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An introduction to the statutes elaborated in Berlin noted that capitalism had faltered following the World War and the revolutions in Russia and Central Europe, but had again passed to the offensive. Two main factors accounted for its resurgence: first, the disorganization and weakness of the working class, which lacked clarity about its objectives; second, the degeneration of the Russian Revolution into a merely political revolution. The syndicalists viewed the establishment of state capitalism in Russia as the political perversion of an economic revolution that had sought to destroy capitalism altogether. "Capitalist Bolshevism," by introducing a system as exploitative and dominating as that of any bourgeois regime, had re-established capitalist economic relations in Russia, thereby fulfilling one of the chief aims of international capitalism. Only a unified fighting organization, embracing the revolutionary workers of all countries, constituted a defense against the concerted attack upon the workers by "exploiters of all kinds." Neither the IFTU nor the RILU fulfilled this goal. The first was mired in reformism and class collaboration, in the expectation that a peaceful revolution would be achieved "with the consent and approval of the bourgeoisie." The second accepted the communist party as the supreme arbiter of revolution and endorsed the dictatorship of the proletariat. But the dictatorship was in theory and practice no more than a statist system, thwarting the expropriatory drive and subverting the sovereignty of the working class. It became thereby "the iron dictatorship of a political clique *over* the proletariat." Hence the need for a true International organized on the basis of syndicalist principles. As a statement of those principles, the congress endorsed the ten-point declaration adopted by the June conference.³⁴

The delegates regarded Giovanetti's proposal to resurrect the title of the the First International particularly appropriate, for it emphasized that the new International Working Men's Association (IWMA) was not a union of political parties, like the Second and Third Internationals, but an international association of revolutionary workers. It also stressed the federalist basis upon which the new International rested.³⁵ In sharp contrast to the centralist attitudes and practice of the CI, the statutes stipulated that congress decisions were not binding upon an affiliate that rejected a decision in its national congress. Alternatively, a decision contested by three affiliates was to be subjected to a referendum of the IWMA's collective membership. These provisions, and the discussion



Fellow officers in the Dutch NAS and opponents on the international issue. Bernard Lansink Jr. (above) supported the syndicalist IWMA and Bertus Bouwman (below) the communist RILU. The issue split the NAS.



The spokesmen for rival Internationals. Above: Aleksandr Lozovskii, the head of the Moscow-based RILU, founded in 1921. Below: Augustin Souchy, from 1922 to 1933 the Secretary of the Berlin-based IWMA. Souchy is pictured in 1936 in Barcelona, where he worked for the CNT during the Spanish Civil War.



of voting rights, again emphasized the federalist basis of the International. The Italian delegation, supported by Lansink, proposed that voting rights be based upon the number of members of affiliated organizations, but yielded to the Germans and Schapiro, who insisted that the federalism of the IWMA required not the "formal democracy of the centralist trade unions," but a recognition of the equal rights of the smaller affiliates.³⁶ The congress unanimously accepted the principle of one country, one vote.

The declared aims of the IWMA were those of strengthening existing syndicalist organizations, and forming new ones, dedicated to the destruction of capitalism and the state. It was to sharpen the class struggle and to oppose the repressive practices of governments against militants devoted to social revolution. The International also undertook to study working class problems in order to develop and guide the international movement, to assist in economic and other conflicts with the enemies of the working class, and to organize material and moral support for the movement in those lands where it remained in the hands of the economic organizations of the proletariat. It was to oppose any efforts by political parties to gain control of the unions. The statutes provided that the IWMA could undertake action in common with other trade union and revolutionary workers' organizations, on a temporary basis.³⁷ The other organizations referred to, however, were never intended to include political parties, and the statutes were later altered to make this exclusion explicit.³⁸ A final clause declared that the IWMA would not intervene in the trade unions of any country, except when an affiliated national organization so requested, or when the latter deviated from the guiding principles of the International.³⁹

The Membership of the IWMA

The membership of the IWMA came almost entirely from Europe and Latin America. In Europe the FAUD, the USI, the SAC, and the CNT quickly affiliated. Referenda determined the issue of international affiliation within the NSF and the CGT-P. The Norwegians voted unanimously to enter the IWMA, while in Portugal 104 unions voted to join, against six for the RILU.⁴⁰ The international question was more laboriously and tumultuously resolved in The Netherlands and France.

In Holland the contest between the Muscovite and Berliner factions

within the NAS determined the outcome of the NAS congress, which withdrew from the defense of Moscow and the IWMA, and that followed the RILU statutes. The Berlin faction altered the congress policies, concluding that it still remained the NAS could have eleven had been argued that the with the Berlin the IWMA called for the of uniting adopted by a partisan and original Berlin autonomy of fully than the differences re argued, the Moscow. A NAS at length. The alterations in of the Berlin foiled his effort of *De Arbeiders* in which approved affiliated IWMA, with a referendum.

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within the NAS continued unabated. Lansink Jr. returned from Berlin determined to rally support for the IWMA, and to combat the entry of the NAS into the RILU, while the official NAS delegation that had withdrawn from the Berlin congress returned equally determined to defend Moscow, and to prevent the affiliation of their organization with the IWMA.⁴¹ Two issues dominated the long and heated controversy that followed: the significance of the abolition of article eleven of the RILU statutes, and the status of the 1920 Berlin Declaration. The pro-Berlin faction argued that the change in the RILU statutes had not altered the organization significantly, that its remaining statutes and policies conflicted sharply and repeatedly with the platform of the NAS, that it still represented the political subordination of the unions, and the NAS could not support it. To the Berliners, the striking of article eleven had been a patently duplicitous act. The pro-Moscow faction argued that the statute alterations had brought the RILU into conformity with the Berlin Declaration of 1920, which the NAS had endorsed. But the IWMA did not reflect the Berlin Declaration they argued, which called for the establishment of an autonomous International capable of uniting all revolutionary unions. The declaration of principles adopted by the June conference of 1922 foresaw the establishment of a partisan and strictly syndicalist International, thereby abrogating the original Berlin Declaration. With the changes establishing the political autonomy of the RILU, it now embodied the Berlin Declaration more fully than the narrowly anarcho-syndicalist IWMA. Although minor differences remained between the NAS and the RILU, the Muscovites argued, the interests of labour unity dictated that the Dutch support Moscow. A NAS congress held in March-April 1923 argued the question at length. The dispute centred primarily on the significance of the alterations in the RILU statutes. Souchy attempted to speak on behalf of the Berlin International, but noisy disruptions by the pro-RILU forces foiled his efforts. The bid of the Muscovites to replace Lansink as editor of *De Arbeid* with their own candidate, however, failed. The congress, in which approximately half of the NAS unions were represented, endorsed affiliation with the RILU by the margin of 99 to 84 for the IWMA, with nine abstentions. The decision was to be submitted to a referendum.⁴²

The issue of international affiliation had been raging for over two years within the NAS when, in May 1923, its members were polled on the question for the third time. Of the larger workers' organizations, those in metal, textiles and tobacco, backed Berlin, while those in construction, transport and public service, the three largest federations,

supported Moscow. By 53 to 47 percent the supporters of the RILU prevailed.⁴³ The minority, however, categorically resisted what many dissidents regarded as subjection to the politicized RILU. Schism threatened. The leading pro-RILU spokesmen recognized that their narrow victory by no means constituted a mandate to carry the NAS into the Moscow International. Having achieved their primary objective – to block the entry of the NAS into the IWMA – they now won the RILU's approval to defer affiliation, in favour of consolidating their position within a unified NAS. A Compromise Committee could therefore readily agree on a variety of points, including postponing a decision on international affiliation until 1925, during which time the NAS would promote the fusion of the Moscow and Berlin Internationals. As for communist cell-building, which the Berliners wished to curtail sharply, the Muscovites to protect, that issue could not be resolved so easily. On neither side would the intransigents accept the final compromise proposal, even when the NAS Executive lent it its imprimatur.⁴⁴ Another contentious issue concerned the editorship of *De Arbeid*. The compromise proposal endorsed the Muscovite position that there be two editors, one representing each international perspective. The Berliners insisted that there continue to be a single editor, representing the viewpoint of the NAS, which for them meant one who honoured the political independence endorsed in the NAS's declaration of principles.

Unity in short required a common ground, a collective will to compromise, to subordinate factional interests, that no longer existed in the NAS. Finding no foundation for unity from below, but convinced that time favoured them, on 21 June the desperate pro-Moscow majority within a divided NAS Executive, backed by the RILU, formally sanctioned the proposal that the international issue be postponed to 1925, but ignored such issues as cell-building and the editorship of *De Arbeid*. Many dissidents, for whom this proposal was a ruse inspired by Moscow, believed they could no longer remain within a communist-dominated NAS. Three days later, gathered in Utrecht, they founded a new national organization, the *Nederlands Syndicalistisch Vakverbond* (NSV), which launched a new newspaper, *De Syndicalist*, and urged the organizations opposed to Moscow to break with the NAS: "You must not delay any longer! Do your duty as true revolutionaries, as libertarian communists, as organized syndicalists!"⁴⁵ The NAS, the first syndicalist organization to have called for the formation of a genuinely revolutionary trade union International at the end of the war, found itself torn asunder by the international question. At its first congress in November 1923 the NSV claimed eleven national labour federations, 150 local organizations, and

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had won about 8,000 of the 22,000 members formerly organized in the NAS. It drew strong support from textile and tobacco workers, above all from metalworkers. By the end of the year the NSV had resolved to enter the IWMA.⁴⁶

Once the results of the referendum on the international question appeared, the break between the pro-RILU group and the NAS minority had followed quickly. By contrast, relations between the dissidents and the CGTU majority in France followed a protracted and desultory course before finally ending in a split. This is largely attributable to the great importance that the minority attached to labour unity, particularly since the French workers' movement had recently experienced the trauma of schism, when the CGTU broke from the CGT. Although the CDS adopted a position of unequivocal opposition following the St. Etienne congress, it also repeatedly cautioned its supporters to remain within the CGTU, which it hoped to recapture. At the international syndicalist congress in Berlin in December, moreover, the delegates of the CDS – hoping to assist their organization in its national work – had persuaded their reluctant colleagues to endorse a resolution leaving open the question of continued relations with the RILU.

But the conduct of the leadership within the CGTU made the task of the new *minoritaires* increasingly difficult. Following Gaston Monmousseau's accession to leadership at St. Etienne, and after the second RILU congress, communist influence expanded within the CGTU. Monmousseau, Semard and other CGTU delegates, as one historian put it, "had gone to Moscow in November 1922 as defenders of the traditional ideas of French syndicalism. They came back Leninists."⁴⁷ This ideological shift contributed significantly to making 1923 the year of communist victory in the CGTU. On 3 January 1923, the PCF reported to the CI Executive that the second RILU congress had greatly facilitated cooperation between itself and the CGTU, which had since drawn far closer to the party. The attitude of the CGTU leadership "is more and more satisfactory," the PCF noted, adding that a joint party-union Action Committee had organized a large meeting in Paris, to protest the Treaty of Versailles and the threat of military action against a Germany that had defaulted on its reparation payments.⁴⁸ In March 1923 the Executive formally enrolled the CGTU in the RILU. Measures were taken to exclude non-communists from positions of authority within the union structure, and to ensure the monopolization of propaganda activities in communist hands. The PCF, moreover, busied itself expanding a party-administered network of Syndical Commissions (mainly propaganda groups) within the CGTU. When the minority objected, the

CGTU Executive quaintly replied that since the Commissions had been established by the party, and not the unions, they were of no concern to the CGTU. These manoeuvres elicited protests from various quarters. In May the CDS sharply condemned the political actions of the CGTU. The powerful *Fédération du Bâtiment*, independently represented at the earlier Berlin congress, but largely supportive of the CDS, vehemently rejected the tactics of the communist-syndicalists. The pressure of the minority made relations between the PCF and the CGTU, already well on its way to becoming a communist fiefdom, the chief issue in the November 1923 Bourges congress of the union organization.

The congress was a turbulent affair with the lines sharply drawn. The minority itself was not united. One group of revolutionary syndicalists accepted membership in the RILU, but bitterly opposed the permeation of the unions by the communists, and the alignment of the CGTU and the PCF. The anarcho-syndicalists, who insisted upon complete syndical autonomy, on the other hand, repudiated not only the union-party linkage, but implacably opposed the RILU as well. Maria Guillot, a dissident revolutionary syndicalist, spoke for all the *minoritaires* when she declared that for months "I saw the syndicalists beaten in the unions, discouraged by a communist coalition who respected neither services rendered to the union movement nor the syndicalist spirit." The communists, Guillot complained, had repeatedly subverted democratic processes within union meetings, the better to disarm those "militants who did not want to bow to the directives of a party." Similarly, Pierre Besnard early in the sessions complained that "the minority has no other rights than paying its dues and being insulted."⁴⁹ Besnard's anarcho-syndicalist faction reiterated the traditional claim that "*le syndicalisme se suffit à lui-même*." Its resolution declared, in part, that "syndicalism, being the natural and concrete expression of the class-movement of the producers, contains in a latent and organic state all the elements of organization necessary for ensuring the life of the new society." The revolution "will be strictly economic or it will not be proletarian." Syndicalism sought not only the abolition of capitalism, but "*the disappearance of the political state*;" to be effective it "must be autonomous. It should not allow itself, therefore, to be drawn into an International committed to the acceptance of a political doctrine."⁵⁰

Emboldened by the predominance they had achieved since St. Etienne, the defiant majority showed little interest in conciliation. A message from the RILU asserted that the PCF had established the Syndical Commissions "of its own accord and it is not obligated to account for

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them to anyone." Purportedly a document of unity, the RILU declaration dismissed union autonomy as "anti-proletarian and anti-revolutionary," and the leaders of the minority as "enemies of the working class, irresponsible careerists." Monmousseau, by now himself a member of the PCF, endorsed the dictatorship of the proletariat and pointedly described himself as a "defender of the Communist International."⁵¹ While the majority professed to pay homage to the traditions of French syndicalism, their resolution diverged sharply from those traditions by virtually sanctioning the active collaboration of the CGTU and the PCF. The convoluted document paid lip service to the "indispensable condition" of syndical autonomy, but dismissed as "dangerous" any interpretation of the *Charte d'Amiens* that saw the social revolution only in economic terms, and therefore denied unionists "the free expression of their political and philosophical opinions within trade union assemblies." The CGTU was to be organizationally autonomous, but, the majority resolution added, "it is not the right of the unions to judge the means" by which a political group promoted its ideas in the trade union movement. Further, the successful resolution simply denied the view "that 'syndicalism is above all else' and all-sufficient," insisting instead that "syndicalism should seek the collaboration of all other revolutionary forces for the accomplishment of its mission."⁵²

The international question was inextricably bound up in the congress debates. Besnard conveyed a message from the IWMA to the delegates. The IWMA Bureau sought to establish the revolutionary credentials of the unions affiliated with it by pointing out that precisely those organizations had opposed the world war and had first welcomed the Russian Revolution, unlike the collaborationist unions in the West. But unfortunately that Revolution, achieved by the avant-garde of the Russian proletariat, had come to be monopolized by a political party, which in turn sought to subordinate the international workers' movement in the interests of state communism. The syndicalists outside France, the Bureau continued, had founded an autonomous revolutionary labour International, which promoted united workers' action, only when it had become clear that one would not emerge from Moscow. "The tactic of the communists - whether Russian or French - is to *speak* of the united front and to *sabotage* it in practice." The communists mouthed platitudes of unity, but in every country their cells within syndicalist unions worked solely "to weaken the revolutionary organization, to strengthen the political party." The communist labour International of Moscow was as unwilling to consider the IWMA's invitation to act together against Italian fascism, for example, as the

reformist International of Amsterdam. But while the IWMA was willing to act with other labour Internationals, it differed sharply from them. Whereas the IFTU was ultimately a tool of bourgeois states, and the RILU an instrument of the Russian government, the IWMA represented only revolutionary workers. It had united all the major syndicalist organizations, except that of France. But the French syndicalists would also soon recognize that the RILU had promised workers' unity, only to sow dissension and facilitate reaction, that the original promise of the Russian Revolution had been subverted. "The halo of the Russian Revolution with which the communists bedeck themselves has become a crown of thorns." The IWMA did not seek to conquer political power, even less to capture it for a political party. "It teaches the great truth of the First International of which it hopes to be the continuation: The emancipation of the workers must be the work of the workers themselves."⁵³

But neither the IWMA's appeal nor Besnard's attack on the CGTU Executive succeeded. A sentence hurled by Semard at Besnard summed up the attitude of most delegates: "It's your right to go to Berlin, but it's our duty to defend Moscow."⁵⁴ The Bourges congress proved a signal victory for the communist-syndicalists. But despite their brusque and hostile treatment, the minority, affirming their allegiance to the CGTU, again placed labour unity to the fore, though this did not prevent them from sharply criticizing the decisions endorsed in Bourges.

Neither the domestic nor the international policy of the CDS appeared to be bearing fruit. In December 1922 the CDS had persuaded the Berlin assembly to accept the Resolution on Revolutionary Unity, regarding further relations with the RILU. In January 1923, shortly after the IWMA had been founded, France and Belgium dispatched troops to occupy the Ruhr in an effort to compel German compliance with reparation requirements. The IWMA Secretariat responded not only by appealing to the French and German workers for joint resistance, but by inviting the IFTU and the RILU to join the IWMA in coordinating international action against the occupation. Neither Amsterdam nor Moscow replied, whereupon the IWMA Bureau condemned both Internationals. In view of Moscow's failure to respond on so serious a question, the Bureau declared the Resolution on Revolutionary Unity to be a dead letter, to have been "automatically rejected" by the RILU.⁵⁵

The first conference of the IWMA, held in Innsbruck in December 1923, endorsed this decision of the Bureau, and sharply criticized the domestic policy of the CDS. The delegates declared the conciliatory attitude adopted by the Berlin congress regarding the CDS to have been

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The vain longing to want to fuse revolutionary syndicalism in the name of an abstract ideal of unity, with the reformist aspirations of Amsterdam or with the vehement dictatorial desires of the Muscovite tendency, or to wish to reconcile them, must lead to the abandonment of the ideas and methods of revolutionary syndicalism, as the bitter experiences of the last years have demonstrated.⁵⁶

This realization, the delegates hoped, might yet become the compass and guide of the revolutionary workers of France.

During 1924 increasing numbers of *minoritaires* in France came to view the quest for unity at any price as untenable. Relations between communists and syndicalists suffered a severe setback at the beginning of the year. On 11 January, during a tumultuous meeting at the *Maison Syndicat*, rue de la Grange-aux-Belles in Paris, communist gunmen suddenly opened fire on their unarmed opponents, killing two dissidents, Poncet and Clos.⁵⁷ The response of the CGTU clearly indicated the communist domination of its governing organs. The CGTU leaders declared that while they deplored these events and reproved "incitements to violence," they had "neither the right nor the duty to exercise a censure upon external groups, on their program and their objectives." A RILU statement placed responsibility upon the *minoritaire* leaders, and expressed confidence that the "conscious syndicalists" of the minority would not "follow the new schismatic manoeuvres of the representatives of the IWMA, who want at any price, by the disintegration of the revolutionary forces, to create their French section."⁵⁸ A CGTU committee of inquiry composed of both *majoritaires* and *minoritaires* eventually concluded that the individual directly responsible for the slayings was a CGTU official and a member of the PCF. The murders of Poncet and Clos had naturally outraged the minority, further embittering relations within the CGTU. The situation continued to deteriorate throughout 1924. From the minority came pointed criticisms of the CGTU, and open acts of insubordination, from the majority violent verbal attacks, and swift action when insubordination went too far. When the Departmental Union of the Rhone defied the central organization by electing a Secretary who was not a CGTU member, for example, the central office supervised the hasty formation of a loyal union structure in the area.

In October the *minoritaires* called for a conference to determine their

course. Some, like Besnard, now urged a complete break with the CGTU. Besnard envisaged three possibilities. The *minoritaires* could reunite with the CGT, but it had ceased to be a proletarian organization and was no more than an organ of the French government, just as the CGTU had become an agency of the Russian government. They could opt for partial or total independence, joining a number of union organizations that since the original schism in the French labour movement had declined to stay in the CGT or to join the CGTU. But this response, at best precarious and provisional, did not resolve the crisis of French syndicalism. The final and best alternative, Besnard argued, was to found a third CGT. He concluded by rephrasing a slogan of pre-war syndicalism: "*Plus un sou, plus un homme pour la CGTU!*"⁵⁹ The publication of a vitriolic attack on the minority by Albert Treint further inflamed the situation. That it came from the hand of the ex-head of the PCF the *minoritaires* found particularly rancorous, since they held Treint morally responsible for the Grange-aux-Belles murders.⁶⁰ Acerbically criticizing the communist-syndicalists, and citing the Treint article, the *Syndicat Unique de Bâtiment de la Seine* broke with the CGTU even before the minority assembly met.⁶¹

The minority conference, held early in November 1924, united not only CGTU dissidents but a number of independent organizations. The assembly adopted the intermediate path of autonomy, which Besnard had characterized as precarious and provisional. But its founders intended the *Union Fédérative des Syndicats Autonomes de France* (UFSA), established to link loosely those unions that opposed the CGT and the CGTU, to be provisional. They hoped the UFSA could build upon and dramatically highlight the widespread disaffection they perceived within the existing Confederations. By providing a temporary shelter for dissidents, whose defection it would encourage, the UFSA would compel the leaders of the CGT and the CGTU to abandon their sectarianism, and to reunite the French movement on its original antipolitical premises.⁶² In this goal the UFSA signally failed. Aside from the initial cost to the CGTU, neither of the two national organizations lost ground to the UFSA. On the contrary, the loosely organized UFSA began to lose members. It proved unable to reverse the steady erosion of strength the minority had suffered since St. Etienne. By 1926 its membership had dwindled.

The ineffectiveness of the UFSA prompted some of its spokesmen to reconsider their strategy. The IWMA encouraged such reassessment. An IWMA Action Committee in Paris began publishing *La Voix du Travail*, in mid-1926, as an official IWMA monthly. The review prop-

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agated the ideals of the Berlin International, and provided an organ for those in the UFSA determined to regroup the syndicalist forces on a more solid basis. Many UFSA leaders now shared the view that had long prevailed within the IWMA: that the quest for unity would be the undoing of French syndicalism. They now saw the UFSA's informal structure and strategy of non-affiliation as a blunder, as counterproductive, as suspending the dissidents in an organizational limbo in the penumbra of the existing Confederations. They believed they had remained too long wedded to the ideal of a united French workers' movement, while their adversaries had subordinated unity to the consolidation of their own power. "Have we not been victims of our own loyalty?" activist Lucien Huart asked. "We had a multitude of scruples *vis-à-vis* men who had none." Huart lamented that the UFSA's policy of autonomy had not yielded fruit, that its loose informal structure had precluded united action and that the unions had lost members. "We have believed in unity," he wrote. "We have sacrificed the very future of our organization to this chimera."⁶³ Huart and others argued that the only solution lay in uniting the minority unionists more firmly in a third national organization, a third CGT. It emerged in November 1926, with the formation of the CGT *Syndicaliste-Révolutionnaire* (CGTSR). The constitutive congress in Lyon offered its "*Motion d'Orientation*" (the *Charte de Lyon*) as a modernized *Charte d'Amiens*. Eighty unions joined the CGTSR, which itself immediately joined the IWMA. The new organization founded a paper, *Le Combat Syndicaliste*, and in April the IWMA ceded *Le Voix du Travail* to its French affiliate, an affiliate that required periodic subsidies from Berlin during its infancy.⁶⁴

Additional IWMA affiliates in Europe included organizations in Austria, Denmark, Belgium and Switzerland. In addition to the Russian Anarcho-Syndicalist Minority, the Federation of Autonomous Unions in Bulgaria, the Anarcho-Syndicalist Trade Union Opposition in Poland, and a Rumanian anarcho-syndicalist propaganda organization, represented eastern Europe.

The IWMA's second major sphere of influence was in Latin America. The FORA of Argentina and the Mexican CGT constituted its most important Latin American affiliates. The struggle between communists and libertarians had been particularly bitter in Argentina, and the FORA (the FORA of the Vth congress), a markedly anarchist organization, was extremely hostile toward Moscow. The *Foristas* took with utmost seriousness the objections raised by their delegates in the founding congress of the IWMA, in December 1922, to further negotiations with

the RILU. Once the news of the Resolution on Revolutionary Unity adopted by the Berlin congress, as a concession to the French CDS, reached Argentina, the outspoken libertarian journal, *La Protesta*, for weeks directed a steady stream of criticism against the IWMA. In its view the resolution involved "nothing less than a sacrifice of the principles and the tactics of the new International." The critical eye of *La Protesta* noted a striking parallel that no one in the Berlin congress had thought to voice:

The congress of Berlin did not want to deal less gently with Besnard than that of Moscow with Monmousseau, and it vied with the Bolsheviks in concessions to the French syndicalists. All the delegates in Berlin who approved the declaration of the French minority have to one degree or another personally violated their sentiments and convictions. The same thing was done in Moscow by the communists.⁶⁵

But even *La Protesta* realized that, given the *Foristas'* unyielding opposition to the RILU and the IFTU, only the IWMA offered an acceptable international shelter. Consequently, when the FORA congress of March 1923 decided to conduct a referendum on the question of conditional affiliation with the IWMA, *La Protesta* considered the caution of the delegates excessive. It argued that the congress should have affiliated conditionally with Berlin, which "would by no means compromise the FORA's own ideology, for until the next congress our organization would be the minority within the IWMA, opposed to the vacillations of European syndicalism."⁶⁶ All doubt about the FORA's formal relations with the IWMA were removed when the International declared the Resolution of Revolutionary Unity to be null and void. The FORA viewed this, and the sharp declaration of the IWMA's Innsbruck conference in December 1923 against the united front, as having salvaged the International, just as it viewed the large loss of support by the French minority, during the years the CDS strove for unity in France, as confirmation of its own view, and further, as the fulfillment of the prediction its spokesmen made to the CDS representatives in Berlin in December 1922.

The affiliation of the Mexican CGT, the FORU of Uruguay and the IWW-C, with the IWMA, also came in 1923-24. Later American affiliates included national organizations in Brazil (*Federacão Regional Operaria Brasileira*) and Paraguay (*Centro Obrero Regional del Paraguay*), and various other associations, either propaganda groups or local union bodies, in Bolivia, Colombia, Peru, Ecuador, Guatemala, Cuba, Costa Rica and Salvador. Some years later the major Latin American members

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of the IWMA also joined the *Asociacion Continental Americana de los Trabajadores* (ACAT), founded at the initiative of the FORA and the CGT-M. Its constitutive congress in May 1929 declared the ACAT to be a direct actionist organization, dedicated to the destruction not only of capitalism, but of the state as well. Its supporters believed the message of the Russian Revolution to be all too clear:

The ACAT considers the free man in the free society to be its highest ideal, and advocates its realization by means of the revolutionary suppression of the capitalist economic organization, and of the state apparatus simultaneously, in the conviction that the abolition of one and the perpetuation of the other leads inescapably, as experience has already demonstrated, to the restoration of the order of things whose destruction was sought.

Augustin Souchy attended the congress in Buenos Aires on behalf of the Berlin International, which the ACAT resolved to enter *en bloc*.⁶⁷

The International also maintained contacts with organizations in Asia, particularly in Japan, China and India, but only in Japan did it have a formal affiliate. In North America only the Marine Transport Workers' Industrial Union adhered. It joined belatedly, in 1935, only after the IWW, of which it was a member, repeatedly declined to do so. The IWW had planned to send a delegation to the Berlin congress, but the organization's 14th congress nullified this decision by formally adopting a position of neutrality. It declared that it would enter neither the Moscow nor the Berlin Internationals, but would maintain friendly relations with both.⁶⁸ The IWMA long and unsuccessfully sought to reach an understanding with the American organization.⁶⁹ In total, the Berlin International had affiliates in thirty-one countries, fifteen in Europe and fourteen in Latin America, between 1923 and 1939.⁷⁰

At the beginning of 1923, however, the IWMA had only just been born, following a long and troubled gestation. Ten years had passed since the first serious efforts to found an autonomous revolutionary labour International in London in 1913. The syndicalists had then viewed the IFTU, dominated by the social democratic centralist unions, as their primary international rival. The impetus of syndicalist internationalism, however, had first been blocked by the outbreak of war, then deflected by the Bolshevik Revolution and the emergence of communist internationalism. The rupture between syndicalists and communists represented not only a breach in the revolutionary wing of the international workers' movement, but the restoration of syndicalist internationalism to its own independent path. Syndicalists now confronted a resurrected, reformist IFTU, and a highly politicized and centralized RILU as well.

The new IWMA, which gave practical organizational expression to the long-thwarted international strivings of the syndicalists, and embodied their conviction that the war and the post-war years had demonstrated the need for a forceful and uncompromising reaffirmation of their principles, thus emerged as the implacable foe of both Amsterdam and Moscow.

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